Coronavirus disease (COVID-19) (WHO)

Overview:

Coronavirus disease (COVID-19) is an infectious disease caused by the SARS-CoV-2 virus.

Most people infected with the virus will experience mild to moderate respiratory illness and recover without requiring special treatment. However, some will become seriously ill and require medical attention. Older people and those with underlying medical conditions like cardiovascular disease, diabetes, chronic respiratory disease, or cancer are more likely to develop serious illness. Anyone can get sick with COVID-19 and become seriously ill or die at any age.

The best way to prevent and slow down transmission is to be well informed about the disease and how the virus spreads. Protect yourself and others from infection by staying at least 1 metre apart from others, wearing a properly fitted mask, and washing your hands or using an alcohol-based rub frequently. Get vaccinated when it's your turn and follow local guidance.

The virus can spread from an infected person's mouth or nose in small liquid particles when they cough, sneeze, speak, sing or breathe. These particles range from larger respiratory droplets to smaller aerosols. It is important to practice respiratory etiquette, for example by coughing into a flexed elbow, and to stay home and self-isolate until you recover if you feel unwell.

Prevention:

To prevent infection and to slow transmission of COVID-19, do the following:

- Get vaccinated when a vaccine is available to you.
- Stay at least 1 metre apart from others, even if they don't appear to be sick.
- Wear a properly fitted mask when physical distancing is not possible or when in poorly ventilated settings.
- Choose open, well-ventilated spaces over closed ones. Open a window if indoors.
- Wash your hands regularly with soap and water or clean them with alcohol-based hand rub.
- Cover your mouth and nose when coughing or sneezing.
- If you feel unwell, stay home and self-isolate until you recover.

Symptoms:

COVID-19 affects different people in different ways. Most infected people will develop mild to moderate illness and recover without hospitalization.

Most common symptoms:

- fever
- cough
- tiredness
- loss of taste or smell.

Less common symptoms:

- sore throat
- headache
- aches and pains
- diarrhoea
- a rash on skin, or discolouration of fingers or toes
- red or irritated eyes.

Serious symptoms:

- difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- loss of speech or mobility, or confusion
- chest pain.

Seek immediate medical attention if you have serious symptoms. Always call before visiting your doctor or health facility.

People with mild symptoms who are otherwise healthy should manage their symptoms at home.

On average it takes 5–6 days from when someone is infected with the virus for symptoms to show, however it can take up to 14 days.

Covid (CDC)

How to protect yourself and others:

Core Prevention Strategies

CDC recommends that all people use core prevention strategies to protect themselves and others from COVID-19:

- Stay up to date with COVID-19 vaccines.
    - Although vaccinated people sometimes get infected with the virus that causes COVID-19, staying up to date on COVID-19 vaccines significantly lowers the risk of getting very sick, being hospitalized, or dying from COVID-19.
- Practice good hygiene (practices that improve cleanliness)
- Take steps for cleaner air

When you are sick:

- Use precautions to prevent spread, including staying home and away from others (including people you live with who are not sick) if you have respiratory symptoms.
    - Learn when you can go back to your normal activities.
- Seek health care promptly for testing and/or treatment if you have risk factors for severe illness. Treatment may help lower your risk of severe illness, but it needs to be started within a few days of when your symptoms begin.

Additional Prevention Strategies

In addition, there are other prevention strategies that you can choose to further protect yourself and others.

- Wearing a mask and putting distance between yourself and others can help lower the risk of COVID-19 transmission.

- Testing for COVID-19 can help you decide what to do next, like getting treatment to reduce your risk of severe illness and taking steps to lower your chances of spreading COVID-19 to others.

What to watch out for

Using these prevention strategies can be especially helpful when:

- Respiratory viruses, such as COVID-19, flu, and RSV, are causing a lot of illness in your community
- You or those around you have risk factors for severe illness
- You or those around you were recently exposed to a respiratory virus, are sick, or are recovering

Testing for Covid-19:

Types of tests

Viral tests look for a current infection with SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes COVID-19, by testing specimens from your nose or mouth.

There are two main types of viral tests.

Nucleic Acid Amplification Tests (NAATs)

A healthcare professional administering a NAAT test.

Nucleic acid amplification tests (NAATs), including PCR tests, are more likely to detect the virus than antigen tests. NAATs tests are the “gold standard” for COVID-19 tests.

Your sample will usually be taken by a healthcare provider and transported to a laboratory for testing and may take up to 3 days to receive results. Some NAATs may be performed at the point-of-care and provide results more quickly.

Antigen Tests

Antigen Test results reflecting a positive result.

Antigen tests* are rapid tests that usually produce results in 15-30 minutes. Positive results are accurate and reliable. However, in general, antigen tests are less likely to detect the virus than NAAT tests, especially when symptoms are not present. Therefore, a single negative antigen test cannot rule out infection.

To be confident you do not have COVID-19, FDA recommends 2 negative antigen tests for individuals with symptoms or 3 antigen tests for those without symptoms, performed 48 hours apart. A single NAAT test can be used to confirm an antigen test result.

**Self-tests, or at-home tests, are antigen tests that can be taken anywhere without having to go to a specific testing site. Read self-test package inserts thoroughly and follow the instructions closely when performing the test.*

When you get tested

- Choose the right type of test for your circumstance.
- When using an antigen test, follow the recommendations provided by FDA and the test's manufacturer.
- If you do not, your results may be less likely to correctly indicate whether you have COVID-19 or not.

Choosing a COVID-19 test

I want to get tested and:

I have not had COVID-19 or I have not had a positive test within the past 90 days.

You may choose a NAAT, including PCR, or antigen test. If you use an antigen test and your result is negative, repeat testing following FDA recommendations.

I tested positive for COVID-19 in the last 90 days.

My first positive test result was within 30 days or less:

- **I have symptoms:** Use an antigen test. Repeat negative tests following FDA recommendations.
- **I do not have symptoms:** Testing is not recommended to detect a new infection.

My first positive test result was within 31-90 days:

- **I have symptoms:** Use an antigen test. Repeat negative tests following FDA recommendations.
- **I do not have symptoms:** Use an antigen test. Repeat negative tests following FDA recommendations.

After a positive test result, you may continue to test positive for some time. Some tests, especially NAAT tests, may continue to show a positive result for up to 90 days.

Reinfections can occur within 90 days, which can make it hard to know if a positive test indicates a new infection.

Consider consulting a healthcare provider if you have any questions or concerns about your circumstances.

Getting a COVID-19 test

Buy self-tests (at-home tests)

Buy self-tests (at-home tests) online or in pharmacies and retail stores. If you have health insurance, it may reimburse the cost of purchasing self-tests. Visit FDA's website for a list of authorized tests.

Go to a testing location

- Visit a community-based testing location, such as a pharmacy or health center near you. These locations may offer NAAT, including PCR, or

antigen tests, and provide low- or no-cost testing. Free NAAT or antigen tests may also be available through your local health department.
- Talk to a doctor or healthcare provider about other testing options that may be available to you.
- If you are a person with a disability, the Disability Information and Access Line can help you access a test or find a test location.

Interpreting your results

If your COVID-19 test is positive

A positive COVID-19 test means the virus was detected and **you have or recently had an infection**.

- Take steps to prevent spreading COVID-19.
- Monitor your symptoms. If you have any emergency warning signs, seek emergency care immediately.
- Seek health care right away for treatment if you have risk factors for severe illness. Treatment may be an option to make your symptoms less severe and shorten the time you are sick. Treatment needs to be started within a few days of when your symptoms begin.

If your COVID-19 test is negative

A negative COVID-19 test means the test did not detect the virus, but this **doesn't rule out that you could have an infection**. If you used an antigen test, follow FDA recommendations for repeat testing.

- If you have symptoms:
  - You may have COVID-19 but tested before the virus was detectable.
  - You may have another viral infection or illness.
  - Take actions to help protect yourself and others from health risks caused by respiratory viruses.
  - Contact a healthcare provider if you have any questions about your test result.

Types of COVID-19 Treatment

COVID-19 Treatment Options

Testing for COVID-19

Testing for COVID-19 can help you decide what to do next, like getting treatment to reduce your risk of severe illness and taking steps to lower your chances of spreading the virus to others.

If you think you could have COVID-19 and are at higher risk for severe illness, talk to your healthcare provider about testing and/or treatment right away, even if your symptoms are mild. If you don't have a healthcare provider, contact your local pharmacy, community health center, or health department.

Don't Delay

Treatment must be started within 5-7 days of when your symptoms first start. You do not need a positive test to start treatment so if you get sick and are at high risk for severe illness, talk to your healthcare provider as soon as possible.

People who are more likely to get very sick include:

- Older adults (especially those ages 75 years or older, with risk increasing with advancing age)
- People who are unvaccinated or are not up to date on their COVID-19 vaccinations
- People with certain medical conditions, such as chronic lung disease, heart disease, or a weakened immune system.

Treatments

FDA has authorized or approved several antiviral medications used to treat mild to moderate COVID-19 in people who are more likely to get very sick.

- **Antiviral medications** target specific parts of the virus to stop it from multiplying in the body once someone is infected, helping to prevent severe illness and death.
- The Infectious Diseases Society of America provides Guidelines on the Treatment and Management of Patients with COVID-19 for healthcare providers to help them work with their patients and determine the best treatment options for their patients. Several treatment options are available for treating COVID-19. They include:

COVID-19 Treatment	**Who (Among people who are at high risk of getting sick)**	**When**	**How**
Nirmatrelvir with Ritonavir (Paxlovid) Antiviral	Adults; children ages 12 years and older	Start as soon as possible; must begin within 5 days of when symptoms start	Taken at home by mouth (orally)
Veklury (remdesivir) Antiviral	Adults and children	Start as soon as possible; must begin within 7 days of when symptoms start	Intravenous (IV) infusions at a healthcare facility for 3 consecutive days
Molnupiravir (Lagevrio) Antiviral	Adults	Start as soon as possible; must begin within 5 days of when symptoms start	Taken at home by mouth (orally)

Some treatments might have side effects or interact with other medications you are taking. Side effects vary for each medication. For example, Paxlovid can cause a metallic taste in your mouth which goes away when you stop taking the medication. Paxlovid is more likely to interact with other medications than other COVID-19 antivirals, but most people can still take it.

Check for possible interactions with your healthcare provider or pharmacist if you are taking other medications to make sure that COVID-19 treatments can be safely taken at the same time.

If you are hospitalized, your healthcare provider might use other types of medications, depending on how sick you are. These could include medications to treat the virus, reduce an overactive immune response, or treat COVID-19 complications.

If you have a weakened immune system, have received antiviral treatment, and continue to experience COVID-19 symptoms, your healthcare provider may recommend additional treatment, including convalescent plasma.

Accessing Treatment

Visit Treatment Locator (hhs.gov) or call 1-800-232-0233 (TTY 1-888-720-7489) to find a location that offers testing and treatment or a pharmacy where you can fill your prescription.

Did you know?

COVID-19 oral antiviral treatments Paxlovid and Lagevrio are available for certain people at a lower cost. Patient assistance programs are available to people who are underinsured, uninsured, who are on Medicaid, and certain people on Medicare to lower their out-of-pocket costs. You should enroll in these programs to learn if you can receive assistance for specific medications, regardless of your insurance status. Call ahead to your healthcare provider and insurer to confirm coverage eligibility.

People have been seriously harmed (and have even died) after taking products not approved for use to treat or prevent COVID-19, even if they were approved or prescribed for other uses. Talk to a healthcare provider about taking medications to treat COVID-19.

Preventing COVID-19

COVID-19 Vaccines

A COVID-19 vaccine is the first step to prevent severe health outcomes. Antiviral treatments are not a replacement for COVID-19 vaccinations.

COVID-19 vaccines available in the United States effectively protect people from getting seriously ill, being hospitalized, and even dying. As with vaccines for other diseases, you are protected best when you stay up to date.

Where to find free COVID-19 vaccines this season

Free COVID-19 vaccines may be available through private health insurance, Medicare, Medicaid, public health safety net programs, and CDC's Vaccines for Children Program.

People with weakened immune systems, who are at higher risk for severe COVID-19 and might have decreased response to vaccination, may require additional doses of COVID-19 vaccine.

Alongside vaccination, practicing core prevention strategies like good hygiene, taking steps for cleaner air, and staying home when sick is vital in preventing the spread of COVID-19.

Pre-exposure Prophylaxis (Medication for Preventing COVID-19)

FDA has authorized a preventive monoclonal antibody for people who are moderately or severely immunocompromised, ages 12 years and older, and weigh at least 88 pounds. In addition to vaccination, Pemivibart (Pemgarda™) may provide another layer of protection against COVID-19 and can be given at least 2 weeks after receiving a COVID-19 vaccine.

A healthcare provider gives Pemgarda as a single intravenous infusion over 60 minutes at a doctor's office or healthcare facility. If continued protection is needed, additional doses should be administered every 3 months.

People who are privately insured or have Medicare part B may receive Pemgarda for free. Talk to your healthcare provider to see if Pemgarda is right for you. CDC is monitoring variants of the virus that causes COVID-19 and how commonly they occur to understand if they might affect how well Pemgarda works. The FDA will provide additional updates to the Emergency

Use Authorization materials, as appropriate, if new information emerges. This is the only preventive option available for COVID-19 for the immunocompromised community, as described above, at the present time.

Recovery

Manage Symptoms

Most people with COVID-19 have mild illness and can recover at home. You can treat symptoms with over-the-counter medicines, such as acetaminophen or ibuprofen, to help feel better.

COVID-19 Rebound

COVID-19 rebound is a return of symptoms or a new positive test 3-7 days after:

- recovering from the initial illness, or
- having tested negative for SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes COVID-19.

People may experience rebound whether they received COVID-19 antiviral medication or not. Rebound symptoms are typically mild and resolve in a few days.

Studies suggest there is no increased risk of severe COVID-19 illness in people who experience COVID-19 rebound after antiviral medication.

The benefits of COVID-19 treatment outweigh the risk of rebound if you are at high risk for severe COVID-19. Talk to your healthcare provider if you think you may have rebound. If you don't have a healthcare provider, contact your local community health center or health department.